Session 47

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Avik Gope
Gender	Male
Age	34
Education	Graduate (B. Com.)
No. of members in the family	Adult: 2 Children:3
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Manufacturing bakery products (raw material) +small dairy business – have own bakery shop and supply items to 30-40 shops as well
Bank account ownership	Bank account in BoB
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 150,000-200,000
Category of respondent	3

Business establishment

His father established the bakery shop 35 years ago in 1984 and which has become one of the busiest markets of Kolkata now - Hathibagan. Then in 2001, their father thought ahead and decided to expand into manufacturing bakery items with the clear intention that within this field it is difficult to control quality of the final product if the quality of raw material is not adequate. Their father decided to start a small cow shed to help create basic raw material i.e. milk for their products. However, the surplus milk was either supplied to customers directly or converted into ghee to be sold through their shop. This way, their father not only tried to maintain the quality of products their bakery created while also removing dependency on other suppliers and creating multiple business streams to reduce volatility risk for their business. This practice still continues.

Managing business activities

He has a very loyal customer base (end-customers and other bakery shops) who are very satisfied from the services. Loyal customer base provides a steady income. On the other hand, to attract new customers he feels their main competition is branded companies, and he offers cheaper and better goods - (as they manufacture the raw materials). They conduct proper recordkeeping of the business by creating bills and then converting them into data for Tally. They had two types of expansion plans for their shop:

a) Go online like Zomato and Swiggy so that customers can order specialized cakes and products . But they do not prefer to tie-up with these applications as they charge very high commission and the USP of their products i.e. low price would vanish since they will have to increase the rates. Avik also spoke of other challenges - to implement online sales: Less knowledge of how to go online, lack of human capital to create orders and deliver throughout Kolkata and how to expand or make changes in their manufacturing base to cater to this. He was made aware of the same when he saw multiple delivery boys (branded with Zomato and Swiggy bags on their back) making deliveries in his market and nearby markets and was thus able to decipher the evolving needs of customers for home delivery.
b) Café setup in the shop – this idea was dropped due to the lack of visibility the shop has.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

While his father was able to take care of basic business risks by moving back into the value chain, there are some other challenges they seem to be facing in their business:

Risks related to human capital – while his brother manages the manufacturing work, he handles the dairy and shop business, and they have 6-7 employees - then it becomes difficult for them to manage things – largely because they do not trust the wages. They have been looking for a full-time manager to manage basic things for them but have not been able to recruit someone who can retain long enough to understand things.

- Their shop has no visibility from the main road, this is because hawkers have occupied all the space in front of his shop. Therefore, any efforts to beautify the shop or any marketing related efforts will have no benefits whatsoever. In addition, they are not able to use the kitchen in their shop as the vent goes out in front of the hawkers so it's been unused currently. If it would have been used he could create customized versions of products in the shop itself i.e. personalized cakes, sandwiches etc. There can be financial risks in any business, to mitigate them their father advised them to get a degree in commerce so that they don't have to be dependent on a third party to manage their personal or business finances. Both brothers use tally to manage their finances and get a clear picture of the position of their business. He mentioned he cannot share more details with regards to finances.

Access and usage levels of banking products

He has a savings and current account but chooses not to disclose any details as he does not feel comfortable. He did mention that he and his brother have not taken any loan from any bank as there has been no need for the same. They are currently pretty occupied with the current business streams and are thinking of consolidating them rather than thinking of any form of expansion of their business because then it will become difficult to handle so much. He doesn't fail to mention that in his work stream a single complaint on quality will have a detrimental effect on his business and might force him to close shop and he cannot afford to take that risk. So focus will always be on increasing existing operations' efficiency rather than expansion, and for operations he does not feel the need for credit at all.

1. Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

He mostly uses his phone for business purposes where he uses YouTube to find and learn how to make new designs of cakes and pastries which are in vogue.

PayTM and PhonePe (mostly this because of recently increased discounts) consist of 40% of the total payments made at his shop, for the rest of the payments he depends on cash, digital payments are mostly initiated by the young population which is why he feels it has a lot of scope of growth for his business as well.

Past learning experience and training support required

They haven't had any past experience of training but feel the following areas can be important areas for capacity building for them:

- Topic 1- How we can get to know our customers better? – They want to understand the needs of the younger population specific to their business so that they can customize their services accordingly.
- Topic 2 – Social media marketing or how to take their business online – this conjures with their expansion plan for the business catering to the young generation
- Topic 3 – Digital payments and its usage for his shop
- Topic 4 – How to customize any training/skill learnt in the current context of business as well as the business environment the entrepreneur is operating in
- Topic 5 – the overall 'Motivation' to sustain business if the business does not do well for some time, when to take a decision to change, expand, diversify or close a business and how .

He feels shopkeepers in this area would feel more comfortable with a digital mode of animation based training because of the lack of time they have at their disposal.

Session 48

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Subrata Ray
Gender	Male
Age	26
Education	8th standard
No. of members in the family	Adult: 2 Children:2
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Imitation Jewellery – Trader (Stall)
Bank account ownership	Bank account in UBI
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 100,000-120,000
Category of respondent	3

Business establishment

His mother started this business 18 years ago and he has been supporting her for a few years now. They have two temporary shops very close to each other, one shop is managed by him and the other by his mother. They have 1 permanent employee and one temporary one (who visits them for 2 months only during the Durga Puja months) because of high sales pressure.

Although he has had some business experience in selling garments (as he used to work in a garment shop before), he still chose to work with the jewellery business. One major reason being that garment business requires the need to have considerable variety and subsequently adequate storage space. The lack of storage space forced him to learn the nuances of a new business rather than use his previous experience. Therefore, he decided to manage the jewellery business started by his mother, rather than start a garment business of his own.

Mother was earlier part of an SHG group when she started her business and slowly expanded her business by taking loans from the group and has now been able to get an individual loan from Ujjivan (Loan amount of INR 1,20.000).

Managing business activities

Managing his business is not an easy thing, more than 500 customers visit his shop on a daily basis and only around 50 actually buy something. So his business profitably depends on ways to increase the number beyond 50 customers. He faces a lot of competition from shops in his area and the only way to differentiate his shop from others is to have a very different and unique collection. So his biggest skills as an entrepreneur are

a) To select the right kind of 'Jewellery pieces' by doing a thorough research on what are the market and fashion trends along either the needs of his customers and

b) Customer handling skills to convince them that this piece is the best one for them.

He sometimes does aspire to have a permanent shop as he feels customer trust them more and thus buy more products from them with the hope that they can come back to this address in case something goes wrong with the product. On the other hand, in his case customers do not buy pieces from him if they have a shadow of doubt.

I usually go to the wholesale market every single day to buy material, most of which I can sell on the same day this is because I have very limited storage space. The money collected by making sales is taken back home, to be used for household expenditure or to buy new material from suppliers the next day, instead of depositing it in the bank.

He normally manages his stock such that he keeps more new and in-fashion items at the front and others stocked behind at the back.

Access and usage levels of banking products

His mother is the one who has been handling payments since the beginning and has a current account in UBI. His mother recently took a business loan from Ujjivan Small Finance Bank amounting to INR 1,20,000 for a period of 24 months. He is not aware of the interest rates (or did not wish to share the same with us). He personally doesn't believe in the concept of loan as he thinks repaying is another form of headache which he doesn't want at this point of time. He also hardly uses any form of banking services.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

He mostly uses his phone for calling purposes or to use Facebook for personal networking purposes. He mentioned that his son is the one who mostly uses his phone to watch Chhota Bheem cartoons and ends up using all of his data for the day in an hour. In addition, he hardly gets time to access to use any other applications on his phone except PhonePe. PhonePe is normally demanded by 1-2% of his customers. He feels digital payments are a form of convenience for some customers for which customers are willing to pay more. For example, some customers who did not have cash, were willing to forego bargaining on the product if a digital payment option is provided

to them. He also uses PhonePe for his personal bill payments – mobile recharge, electricity bill payment etc. and finds it very convenient.
He has heard about Paytm Mall for his business but feels he doesn't have the necessary knowledge to understand and manage the same.

Past learning experience and training support required

He hasn't had any training experience in the past and feels there is hardly any type of topic on which he feels he needs training, this is because he feels he has been in this business for a long time and has learnt the tricks and trade of it to get through.

- After much probing, he did feel their maybe skill gaps at his end and he suggested that we create material which will initially help him identify the skill gap he has. Only after that first level of identification can he then decide to take up any form of training.
- He feels that customer service cannot be a skill gap as he feels a customer buys only if they want to and his convincing skills can only work up to a certain limit. On the other hand, he felt only if we can show him the material we plan to cover as part of training, he can understand if this is a skill gap for him.
- However, digital payment options and ways to use it to increase business – this is one topic which he would be very keen on learning.

He would want to watch short modules of videos which first talk about theory and then teach him how to use it practically for his business. For example, in the lean business periods he can watch this video while sitting in his shop and then maybe he can test out the theory in the evening when he interacts with a customer.

Session 49

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Ashish Kumar Roy
Gender	Male
Age	39
Education	Higher secondary (12th)
No. of members in the family	Adults: 2 Children: 2
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Has a garments business
Bank account ownership	Both savings and current account
Type of mobile phone	Jio Phone (smart feature phone)
Monthly revenue from business	INR >100,000
Category of respondent	3

Business establishment

His garments shop deals in both the ready-made and tailored products, and for both men and women. It is a 60-year-old ancestral shop started by his father. The shop is located in a busy retail marketplace in Kolkata which sees a mega customer footfall for all sorts of products like garments, footwear, jewelry, etc. The shop is well-lit but without air-conditioning. The business is conducted over the counter. On the first floor there is a tailoring unit owned by him as well where tailored garments are made. The shop complies with all the legal and statutory requirements like trade license registry and submitting GST taxes.

Managing business activities

He manages the shop's operations all by himself, without hiring any workers. For financial planning, he takes the support of his mother who is the actual owner of the shop. He stocks different product lines from his chosen supplier network only. He has his fixed suppliers for materials as he has to ensure quality otherwise risk losing his loyal customer base acquired for generations. This factor of quality makes his sourcing limited as he does not want to enter into business relationships with new suppliers whose may compromise on quality.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

The biggest risk in his business relates to the risk of reputation. If he is not able to serve the customer requirements adequately, he will eventually lose his clientele. He has to stay abreast of the latest trends and demands in the market so as to provide customers a compelling one-stop option for their garments needs. He does this by observing his clients and their preferences, and deciding options with the suppliers.
Other risks relate to shop establishment risks like fire and threat for which he has taken a general insurance.

Access and usage levels of banking products

The access and usage of banking products is pretty high in terms of savings and current account. With regard to credit, there is a great apprehension of taking out loan from the banks. It is not only cumbersome but also risky in case one is not able to pay back the regular installments. He wants to do his business growth in small incremental manner without resorting to a credit dose. This is what he has learnt in this line of business over the past 60 years of existence of the shop i.e. one should have patience rather than merely capital.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

He conducts his entire operations in cash only. This cash regime he follows with both suppliers as well as customers. He hasn't jumped on the digital bandwagon at all, although he is aware that many merchants are going digital in his marketplace. He is conservative in his approach and wants to keep the things simpler for himself. He says that any of his customers who come to his shop will not come empty-handed to shop, they will either come with money ready to pay or be in a position to withdraw money from a nearby ATM. So there is no need for him to go digital in the payments.

Past learning experience and training support required

All the learning that he has acquired in this field is on-the-job. Some basic understanding of customers' preferences and behaviors he had gathered from his salaried job in Odisha long time back. After that, with handholding from his parents, he has been able to master the skill and the art of running this business. But at the same time, he feels he doesn't have the skills to acquire new customers in the market; his clientele mostly consists of the old loyal customers who have been coming to his shop over generations (like mother to daughter, etc.). More to the point, he is not even aware that he can acquire suitable skills that help him get new customers.

Session 50

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Raja Gupta
Gender	Male
Age	38
Education	Higher secondary (12th)
No. of members in the family	Adults: 2 Children: 2
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Personal care products and men's garments
Bank account ownership	Current account
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone
Monthly revenue from business	INR >100,000
Category of respondent	3

Business establishment

He runs a 50-year-old ancestral shop which deals in personal care products, cosmetics and garments. He has personally been handling the business for the past 12 years. The shop is registered and complies by taxes.

Managing business activities

He manages the different lines of businesses in his shop with his sister (a widow). While he deals with men's garments, his sister takes care of cosmetics and personal care products. They have four workers as well who become particularly handy when there is a good customer footfall in the evening and attention needs to be given to all the customers. Also, the employees become useful when he or his sister need to go to the supplier in the afternoon for fetching supplies, while they sit at the shop attending to any customer. These employees have been with the shop for a long time, so are trustworthy.

He takes out money every day from his sales revenues to pay for the different supply creditors the next day, as per the payable dates and modes. Whenever the different product expires, the suppliers readily replace them, on notifying them. On Sundays, he consolidates the entire week's sales from the cash memos into a formal register for bookkeeping.

He tries to keep the branded products most of the time as they have good customer recall and trust. He has to spend a lot of time explaining unbranded products to customer in order to secure their sale, so doesn't stock them even if they contain better margins.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

The biggest risk he faces is in terms of lack of sales on any given day. He feels that if he has access to wholesale suppliers rather, he might be able to source products at lower costs, attracting more customer footfall through discounts.

He had started diversifying into women's garments as well, but didn't continue afar. He felt that women customers were demanding and he didn't have the skill sets to match the expectations of this clientele. So he

discontinued it and restricted himself to men's garments only as they are a much easier gender segment to deal with.
During the time of demonetization, he didn't face much trouble as he sourced more supplies to stock them up with the cash reserve of INR 500 and 1000 currency notes.

Access and usage levels of banking products

He doesn't prefer banking for his personal financial needs. Availing credit from banks has many headaches—he doesn't want to get into the nexus of monthly compulsory installments. He wants more flexibility in repayment which no bank can provide.
He cites the reason that banks must trust him as he has an ancestral shop and he is not going to just pack one day and run away leading to a NPA for the bank. In terms of flexibility, the suppliers offer him much better deal in terms of repayment with extension and relaxation given up to even 15 days. He says he has to be good at his creditworthiness through repayment to suppliers, otherwise his reputation might get marred not only with a particular creditor supplier but overall in the local trade supply industry as well.
He operates a current account for his business at HDFC bank nearby. Whenever he has cash surplus left at the evening which he can preserve or he needs to issue a cheque for supplies, he deposits money in this account in the morning the next day before opening the shop.
He has also taken a LIC policy for his family.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

He has put the Paytm sticker at the front of his shop in case someone wants to pay through that mode. Nonetheless, most of the customers pay through cash only with less than 10% payments through digital modes.
Recently he has also installed a swipe machine since the vendor offered an enticing discount, the only incentive to buy it considering he is going to have to use it occasionally.
He uses a smartphone and has downloaded various common apps, primarily for entertainment.

Past learning experience and training support required

A major skill gap they he faces is in dealing with customers. He thinks he can benefit from understanding the consumer behavior in a much-nuanced way. (*We have observed that depending on type of business, entrepreneurs' demand on understanding customer varies – if they are in a business like garments/fashion related industry it is always high, for FMCG merchants this need is not high*)

Day 2 (11th June, 2019)

Session 51

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Subrata Saha
Gender	Male
Age	46
Education	12th standard
No. of members in the family (except them)	Adult: 2 Children: 0
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Photocopy and printing – Trader
Bank account ownership	Bank account in UBI
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 25,000-30,000
Category of respondent	1

Business establishment

His family had a manual printing business where he not only learnt the basics of running a business from his father but also the technical basics of printing. He had always wanted to start something of his own and so in 1999 he foresaw the need for semi/automatic printing and bought a machine to start his business, with financial help from his father. (His family owned multiple assets in form of properties (residential and commercial) so financially he has a good backing.) Luckily his business picked up well, as an office space was opened right in front of his shop and his shop was the one of its kind to cater to their printing needs. It was only a few years later that the office closed and small printers were bought by households that his business started to suffer. On the other hand, the inheritance of 2 shops and a house kept him afloat financially. His hobby was singing and he started exploring the commercial opportunities in that space and formed an orchestra to sing at functions earning INR 5.000-6,000 per night. After a while, this business became a secondary means to financially run his household. The monthly turnover from their business is INR 15,000 -30,000. The two major assets he has bought for his shop are a) Small colored printer (Epson brand) and b) Large multi-purpose black and white printer and photo-copier machine (Canon brand). The multi-purpose machine is a second-hand machine (one year old only) imported from Japan three years ago at 30% of the cost-price from a supplier (Original price is 5,00,000 and paid price is INR 1,50,000).

Managing business activities

He has trained his son to manage and run the business especially on how to use and manage the machine. Training on customer servicing skills is an element which his son has learnt through observation and practice. For record-keeping he tries to regularly maintain a proper entry register which is hard to manage because of the low transaction size their business deals with (INR 5-20 per customer).

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

Some of the major risks or challenges he foresees in his business are:

- Lack of trustworthy human capital – this has been a major limitation when he wishes to expand to other business areas for increased income. He tried to diversify by starting a men salon shop but the inability

to handle the quality of service delivered by employees and to source material for the shop, led him to close the business. After this experience, he was able to realize that his current business requires minimum management compared to other businesses. In other business, a majority of the time is spent on sourcing raw material and keeping stock inventory and therefore requires more intensive forms of management.

- Maintenance of machine – the canon machine he has bought should ideally be kept in an air-conditioned environment, but the cost of installing an A/c in his shop is too high. Therefore, he prefers to get a regular check-up instead of the machine every 2 months instead of the prescribed 6 months. This is however a risk in his business as the machine is the single biggest asset of his business.

Access and usage levels of banking products

He has a savings account in BoB specifically for the purpose of savings where he has made good use of products like RD and FD. Using a bank account was saving purposes was a habit triggered after a specific event where he lost his life savings of INR 35,00,000 in the Sahara chit fund crisis. After which he has been hugely drawn to formal financial services as a means to save and grow his money. He recently applied to Ujjivan for a loan (amounting to INR 70,000 at interest rate of 22%) to finance purchase of a colored multi-purpose printing, scanner and photocopy machine. He prefers to take loan although he has some savings as he believes taking a loan helps him file his ITR easily (When probed further on the details, he was unwilling to share more details). However, after his loan was sanctioned the machine was not available in the second-hand market with his trader of choice. This led him to mention that though banking services are secure, the processes are long and full of hassles. For businesses, time of loan disbursement is the most important element otherwise the credit service loses its relevance.

He has not thought about opening a current account till now, as he doesn't feel the same provides him any additional benefit as he doesn't transact for his business needs through the bank.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

He has been using a smartphone for the past few years but is comfortable only with using WhatsApp and Facebook for networking with friends and not for business purposes. He has also not been using any form of digital payments, as his transaction size is too small for customers to consider any benefit (cashbacks etc.) from digital payments compared to the hassle of using it.

Past learning experience and training support required

While he foresees some areas of learning for his business, he has no plans to invest concentrated efforts in his business in future. So, he does not wish to spend time on training. He wants both him and his son to concentrate on the music orchestra and the printing business would be eventually reduced to an activity to keep them both occupied.

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Session 52

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Sanjoy Dutta
Gender	Male
Age	48
Education	10th standard
No. of members in the family	Adult: 2 Children:1
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Selling stationery items (Pen and folders) – Trader having a stall
Bank account ownership	No bank account
Type of mobile phone	Feature phone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 25,000-30,000
Category of respondent	1

Business establishment

He used to sell religious calendars as a small hawker near the Park street metro station after which he was able to gather adequate capital to start trading in items like pillow covers. He was able to do this after taking loan from Bandhan MFI through his wife who was part of an SHG group with them 10 years ago. However, since he has a birth disability in his leg which limits his movement, he found it difficult to carry the heavy stock from home to the business location and back. It was then that he decided to trade in light items like pens which he can carry comfortably on a daily basis.

Managing business activities

His wife helps him to manage the business and sometimes would visit the suppliers on his behalf to source pen refills etc. The sales agent delivers him the branded pens at his home or business location which saves both him and his wife frequent visits to the markets for supplies. He has a very loyal customer base of customers working in offices near to his location on Park Street.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

Some of the major risks or challenges he foresees in his business are:

- Lack of credit facility to grow his business further hampers his growth to become eligible for a formal credit product. Therefore, he feels he is stuck in a vicious cycle.
- His physical disability limits the category of products he can sell as he is required to carry them between home and market on a daily basis

Access and usage levels of banking products

He has been able to sustain and grow his business based on the small loans (INR 20,000-30,000) taken from Bandhan on a 22% interest rate. He is currently paying INR 850 on a weekly basis to them as re-payment. He also mentioned that he was approached by UCO bank for a MUDRA Sishu loan, and even though his wife had a good credit history of 10 years they did not provide him the loan. He was disappointed to experience that even after paying multiple high interest loans for the past 10 years he was denied this loan (His stall is hardly 100 meters from the UCO branch where his loan was rejected and from where he has been operating his business for the past 10 years).

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

He currently uses a feature phone only for calling purposes. He feels his business does not entail the need for digital payments for his average transaction size of INR 10. Also, he cannot afford a smartphone with his current income, which is a minimum requirement to do digital payments and neither does he have the knowledge or skill to learn the use of a smartphone.

Past learning experience and training support required

He is too caught up in the income and credit cycle to sustain his business that he is not able to think beyond it. He is also not enterprising enough to think of new lines of business he could get into considering he is doing business in one of the busiest market places in Kolkata with customers having an above average income base. While he has some level of market intelligence to diversify into folders especially before the rainy season as people will buy it to keep their documents free from getting wet. He needs some form of training to be able to diversify his product portfolio more efficiently.

The only vision he has is to have enough capital to buy and sell parker pens, so that he can cater to a customer base a notch higher to his current customers. He believes, this new customer base will be very sticky as they have a personal brand preference and would not buy only one stock item but more. This will not only help his business grow but also increase his margins and profits.

"***Bade log aaenge to aur bhi cheezen kharidenge***"

Session 53

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Kamlesh Gupta
Gender	Male
Age	33
Education	9th standard
No. of members in the family	Adult: 2 Children: 1
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Trading
Bank account ownership	Yes
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone
Monthly revenue from business	Up to INR 50,000
Category of respondent	1

Business establishment

Kamlesh runs a busy kirana shop in a densely populated area of Kolkata. His shop is 10 years old. His family had migrated from Bihar and taken up odd jobs in the city. Earlier, he had taken an adjacent shop on rent for the same business, but has since then moved to this owned shop based on his accumulated savings. His shop is registered and he pays taxes.

Managing business activities

He manages his day-to-day business activities with a lot of cash-intensive transactions. He uses the money he earns daily to acquire products from suppliers on the succeeding day. Also, he runs credit lines with some customers, who pay him weekly or monthly, since he practically knows every household in the neighborhood. He records these credit lines in his notebook. Similarly, for dealing with suppliers he maintains a register for cash-worth of products purchased. He notably doesn't maintain records of his customer-related transactions where there are no credit lines. 70% of his sales are in real-time cash transactions with rest 30% run as credit lines.
For acquiring new products launched in the market, he depends on the market intelligence from customers enquiring about new products which they may have seen in advt. He runs his business in the morning hours from 7AM to 2PM and then in the evening from 5:30PM to 11:30PM. When he needs to go and fetch his supplies from Sealdah, his wife manages the shop in the meanwhile for a few hours.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

A challenge he faces in his business is that all the suppliers don't trust him giving their products. So his product lines stretch to only a few selected brands. He feels he needs to own a bigger shop where he can prove he can keep the stock for potential sale to customers. Also, for inventory handling, he has recently renovated his shop by adding new shelves to it with the help of a carpenter. (The shelves are still over-the-counter with no direct access to customers.) Also, demand has shifted to more cold storage products, so he had to recently upgrade from a small refrigerator to a more commercial model found in supermarkets. On similar lines, he feels a go-down can help him stock more and get a better bargain from different suppliers. Overall his biggest challenge is

to source supplies from different suppliers and brands through a one-stop solution. (As we see later, his use of the Udaan app becomes crucial here for him.)

Access and usage levels of banking products

He has a loan running with Ujjivan which he is using to expand in his current shop. Similarly, he has taken a MUDRA loan (Kishore category, INR 0.1 million) for buying more fixed assets in his shop. The loan was provided by Bank of India (BoI) which is located nearby and where he has an account as well. The bank staff themselves came to sell him the loan. He believes that general insurance of the shop is part of the overall loan package as well. (We confirm from MUDRA website that no such bundling is done, indicating a halo effect on him.) He has also done an LIC for his family. He knows how to issue cheques and does that regularly for his suppliers like HUL. Depending upon the fact that he has issued a cheque in favour of some supplier, he subsequently goes and deposits equivalent amount in the bank. Otherwise, he keep the cash rolling for daily stocking from different suppliers.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

Although his shop includes all usual promotional material given by mobile wallet companies, there is hardly any digital transaction. The cash dealing that we observed were so swift that nobody bothers to pay through the digital means which may take more time for them at that point of time. Also the ticket size of transactions is so low (sometime even INR 1–5) that it doesn't justify payments through digital means. Nonetheless, he has a PhonePe account which is linked to his BoI account.

Significantly, he has started using an app called Udaan lately after it was sold to him by a sales representative from the fintech firm. He orders some of his supplies directly from there rather than sourcing it through different suppliers that visit him or going to wholesale market in Sealdah. The app saves a lot of hassles for him and the goods arrive the next day with cash on delivery option. Still he feels that the app doesn't provide all the stocks currently and he has to depend on physical suppliers.

Past learning experience and training support required

A training support he mentions is about customer dealing, especially when it comes to attracting new customers. He wants to know how he should handle them and their demands. Also, he wants an understanding of bargaining effectively with his customer base. Similarly, since he doesn't have any time at all to search things on internet, he wants ready access to information through another mechanism about the market trends; currently it is only through customer demand for a novel product that he comes to know of market dynamics. [*He might be actually looking for more ways to engage with customers so that he know what they want. Currently his engagement is limited to less than 5 min when they come and ask for a good.*]

Session 54

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Gautam Sen
Gender	Male
Age	29
Education	12th standard
No. of members in the family	Adult: 2 Children: 1
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Mobile repair shop
Bank account ownership	Savings a/c
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone
Monthly revenue from business	Up to INR 50,000
Category of respondent	1

Business establishment

Gautam runs his mobile repair shop on one of the main traffic streets in Kolkata. At this shop, he also does other side business related to mobiles like recharges, data transfer in USBs, etc. But his primary business is into mobile repair—both smartphones and feature phones. This shop is his ancestral property. It is registered, pays taxes and complies with other statutory requirements. He started learning about getting into mobile related business from his cousin, under whom he did his apprenticeship earlier. At that point of time, with data access a luxury, he used to download movies, music, etc. for customers.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

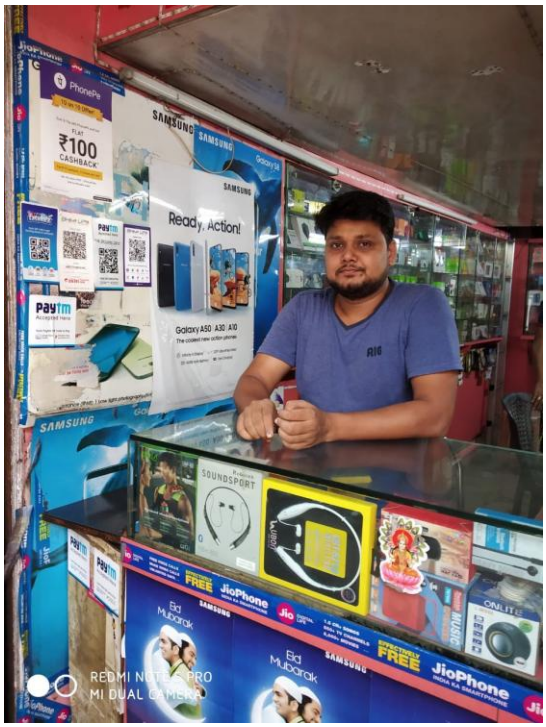
He is unable to think of new lines of business to hedge against the growing threat from the digital world. The digital world has grown right before his eyes and yet he has not been able to either pivot appropriately or enter new lines of business outside of digital reach. The mobile repair is the only safe associated business left for him but he doesn't get much earnings from it in his current shop. He doesn't want to open another different line of business as it might affect his present customer base from existing line of business; he will be unable to cope with the risk in transition.

He doesn't trust keeping employees as they may siphon off the money and the customers complain about their service delivery. He has been a victim in past experiences. This has prevented him from going to a busier market place where there could still be more demand for mobile repairs. In that case, he would have to keep an employee for his current shop or put in place a commission-based model. He says that both the models don't seem to work, as there is a lot of underreporting of revenues.

Finally, he has a confirmation bias that he understands his market area very well as he has grown up there. So there is nothing in the local market dynamics that he isn't aware of. But when probed that right in front of his eyes big businesses have emerged out of nowhere whose value proposition resonated with a customer 'job' in his area like Paytm, OYO, Swiggy, etc. he accepts that may be there is still something about the local market need he is not able to crack.

Access and usage levels of banking products

He has a personal savings account in SBI. But his day-to-day transactions happen primarily in cash transfers rather than resorting to safe keeping in bank. He deposits money in bank only when he needs to pay through cheque. He has an LIC in his name which was started by his father.



Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

He purchases various parts for mobile repair online. He uses an e-commerce app called SHOPX to source the supplies. The salesperson of the fintech firm told him about the app, he liked it and started using it by downloading from Play Store.

He feels that while we still speak about the look and feel of the physical product as major consideration for buying offline, the massive discount available online at e-commerce sites overrides that factor considerably.

All the mobile wallets and UPI stickers are suitably displaced in his shop. Yet he doesn't use Paytm, PhonePe, etc. as the ticket size of his transactions is very low.

He uses YouTube, Facebook, etc. primarily for his leisure and entertainment.

Past learning experience and training support required

He feels that currently he is unable to think of any particular skill need which can revamp his business. He is not able to visualize any support which may prove useful to him given his catch-22 situation.

Day 3 (12th June, 2019)

Session 55

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Jadavpur
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Rural
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Deepali Panda
Gender	Female
Age	55
Education	3rd standard
No. of members in the family	Adults: 2 Children: 1
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Manufacturing
Bank account ownership	Yes
Type of mobile phone	Feature phone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 50,000-100,000
Category of respondent	2

Business establishment

Deepali is into the snacks manufacturing business, continuing the enterprise established by her deceased husband. The enterprise is running for close to 40 years with her running it ever since she got widowed around 30 years back in 1991. The enterprise is equipped with heavy machines and utensils which are used for snacks production. The shop is registered, and complies with all tax and other statutory requirements.

Managing business activities

The business is run on a day-to-day business of production and sale to retailers. There is obviously more demand during festivities like Durga Puja and family celebrations. She has 4 workers whom she trains in this business for around 6 months to help them acquire adequate production and sales skills.

Based on the incomes she has generated from her core business in manufacturing, she has been able to construct more floors on her single-storied house. Now she has put two of the rooms for rent as well, giving her a secondary source of fixed income over the more volatile cash flows she receives from her primary snacks business. Interestingly, she is able to practice mental accounting wherein the rent income is used only for household expenditures whereas the snack manufacturing business income is reinvested mostly in the business only.

Finally, one of her unmarried daughters who stays with her works in a nearby mall and also contributes to household affairs. She doesn't interfere or gets involved much in the manufacturing business.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

Deepali's biggest concern relates to the fact that she may not be able to meet the customer demand all the time, hurting her reputation. In such times of stress, she generally collaborates with other distant manufacturers to meet the demand. This form of favour is returned when the other manufacturers' demands escalate, making it a social norm in this business community. There is no commission paid or received in such business deals.

Another big challenge she faces regularly is the attrition of employees, who get lured by higher wages offered in other sectors in the nearby marketplace. She has put in place measures like leave policy, flexibility in

workplace reporting, etc. but to no avail. When the worker leaves, there is a drop in sales for the time being till the replacement is found, because she can't visit the retail outlets herself for sales due to her old age.

There is a big question mark over the future of the business after she passes away. Her daughters are/will get married with their own families to take care of, leaving no one to take care of the business operations on a day-to-day basis. As of now, she is not willing to close down the shop and retire, as the business is the embodiment of her husband's memory. Her daughters need a vital push to ensure the business continues after her, as currently the priming to their father's legacy and mother's preserve is preventing them from independently assessing the future potential of this well-established and well-oiled business. (Deepali needed the same push from a well-wisher when she decided to carry-on her husband's business and not sit and mourn about him all the time.) Moreover, the daughters fear the hassles involved in managing the whole business in terms of time, capital and other intensive inputs.

Deepali hasn't thought much amount rising up the supply chain and catering directly to the huge snack-lover customer base that she has, either directly through online mode or opening a retail front of one's own. Also, she hasn't thought about getting into other snack items as well which might hedge her business against downside risk from a single product. Similarly, she has a status quo in favor of an old machine rather than buying a more efficient new machine. (This must be qualified though, as she believes her old machine produces better quality than what new machines can deliver.)

She maintains katcha bills for her business, both with suppliers and retail outlets where she sells her produce. She is consequently unable to retrieve old bills as part of records management. On probing, she realizes the importance of bookkeeping as it might improve her profile and lead to better loan deals.

Access and usage levels of banking products

She has a bank account in SBI, although it lies dormant most of the time. She sees no point in keeping money in the bank, as she has to settle transactions on a real-time basis day-in day-out with suppliers and retail merchants. She hasn't ever applied for a hefty bank loan, fearing she will not be able to repay it. Also, in case she passes away, she doesn't want her daughters to be put into the burden of repaying the debt. She has only incrementally applied for small ticket-size loans from Bandhan Bank and Sarla Microfinance.

She had earlier invested in chit funds, but doesn't do it any more ever since the unravelling of the pervading scams in the sector in the near past. She has done an LIC policy as well for herself and her family.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

She is digitally inept, given her age. She uses a basic feature phone which she uses for pure calling only—personal and business-related. She does not think it is a good idea to let one of her staff /daughters learn it and use it for the business.

Past learning experience and training support required

She believes herself to be self-sufficient in her business skills, having single-handedly managed the enterprise for close to 30 years and meanwhile raise her daughters and construct a three-storied house. Although she doesn't

need any explicit training demand on running her business, she and her daughters require support on succession planning so as to ensure the business flourishes.

Session 56

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Safruddin
Gender	Male
Age	44
Education	8th standard
No. of members in the family	Adult: 2 Children:5
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Biryani food joint
Bank account ownership	Bank account in SBI
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone (for shop) and Feature phone for personal use
Monthly revenue from business	INR 25,000-30,000
Category of respondent	1

Business establishment

He had an auto repair business set-up in Jharkhand for 10 years and was earning very well, but due to limited availability for skilled employees he had to close down his business. He then decided to setup a biryani good shop in Kolkata due to following reasons: a) In-laws are residing in Kolkata, b) Brother-in-law has a rented shop in Kolkata, c) Skilled resources available in his village who are known for cooking biryani very well, and d) Demand for biryani in Kolkata. Therefore, in 2016 he and his family shifted with his in-laws and he started his business in a small shop. (rented for INR 10, 000). He had employed 2 chefs as employees who travelled from his hometown in Jharkhand to accompany him in his business. His business had picked up well due to the differentiable taste his biryani was able to offer. Unfortunately, his previous landlord was looking to increase the shop rent substantially and as a result he had to shift the location of his shop about 4 months ago. He is currently not too fond of the location of his shop as it has limited visibility from the main road. To mitigate this, he has deployed some marketing techniques a) A banner on the main road pointing to his shop, and b) Getting pamphlets printed and employing 2-3 boys (paying them a sum of INR 300 per day) to distribute them to college going kids in the vicinity.

I have named my shop as A1 Arsalam as there is a famous biryani shop by this name i.e. Arsalam and adding A1 to it protects me from any trademark related issues.

Managing business activities

He admits that he has no knowledge of the food business, and thus to mitigate this risk he has employed a very able chef who has considerable experience in this area. He has a rented godown near his shop where all the food is cooked and then transferred to the shop. He has a footfall of around 100-150 customers at his shop on a daily basis with half of them visiting for take-away and the remaining eat-in.

He has set strict quality protocols for his shop the most important of which is to source the chicken on a daily basis and cook fresh food daily as well. He has been able to do some form of approximation of the demand and as a result he hardly has any food wastage at hand.

In terms of sourcing raw material, most of his input products (chicken, rice, mutton, oil, vegetables etc.) are delivered to him by the supplier in the morning and the payment for which is collected in the evenings. Through this process he is able to rotate his cash-at-hand as cash collected from customers is paid to the suppliers. The remaining cash which is very negligible he currently takes with him to his house. The only raw material for which he visits the mandi (near his house) is the masalas which he methodically gets grinded and mixed to give an aroma which is the USP of his shop. This USP helps him compete with other similar shops in his area.
He is able to keep good records of his business and is thus able to calculate through numbers that he is struggling in terms of finances. But he is confident that once his business picks up he will start making profits.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

Some of the major risks or challenges he foresees in his business are:

- Competition from other online businesses, he is trying to cope up with this risk by always thinking of innovative ways to offer good quality biryani at even reduced prices. He sources branded products to control quality of food.
- Ways to offer personalized services to customers to deal with competition, he has been thinking of employing his own delivery person to deliver to his regular customers and to save on the commission he needs to pay to Zomato/Swiggy. The major challenge he is facing in this regard is the unavailability of a delivery person who knows the local area well.

Access and usage levels of banking products

He has a bank account in SBI which he rarely uses once every 2-3 months. He does not believe in the principles of giving or taking interest on loan because of his religious beliefs. Infact, he was recently approached by HDFC bank for a Mudra loan but he rejected the same.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

He currently owns a feature phone for personal use and a smartphone specifically for business purposes. Smartphone was bought after his tie-up with Zomato and Swiggy which required the same. He gets an average of 12-15 orders from these tie-ups. I came to know about Zomato/Swiggy after they visited my shop for a tie-up and I felt this is a conducive way to increase my customer base and visibility. He has also started using the smartphone for personal use e.g. YouTube for watching movies, videos on biryani recipes and Hotstar to see cricket matches.
He is aware that his target segment is college going students, as his shop is located near Jadavpur University, therefore he understands that using digital forms of payment is an all-important skill he needs to learn.
He also limits digital payments to his suppliers as they provide him a discount of 1-2% on using cash.

Past learning experience and training support required

Some of the areas in which he feels learning gap is currently present and he needs support are:

- Ways to attract new customers to his shop and ways on specifically influencing the young population to try food from his shop
- Ways to search content on the internet

He is willing to receive training videos on his WhatsApp number which he can then watch on YouTube. He was very involved in the animated BCFI videos shared with him.

BIRYANI

Day 4 (13th June, 2019)

Session 57

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Semi-urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Baladev Chatterjee
Gender	Male
Age	51
Education	12th standard
No. of members in the family	Adult: 2 Children:2
Business is primary income source	Yes, have another business of match-making
Business type	Wallpapers and home decor
Bank account ownership	Bank account in Central bank
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 80,000-100,000
Category of respondent	2

Business establishment

He earlier had a match-making business which was doing well but had limited scope for expansion. Therefore, in 2014 he bought this shop to start the wallpaper business. There were specifically three reasons for choosing this business a) Preference of the new generation for wallpapers (increase in demand in future), b) Stock has no expiry date c) No competition in the area. While he would have preferred a shop at a more prominent location, finances was the limitation. He got a gold loan for INR 1,00,000 from the bank to start his business while buying the shop from his savings.

He currently sources his material from Delhi/Mumbai based on customers demand. Although there are no return policies on his products, he is well aware of the market demand and chooses his stocks accordingly.

Managing business activities

He does proper record-keeping for his shop financials as he needs to submit details to the accountant who files his GST. But he wants to do his record-keeping digitally, such that he saves times on entering and analyzing information.

He believes that due to limited customer footfall while he is not required to spend a lot of time handling customers at his shop, digital market is probably one channel through which he can reach customers. After having done thorough research on the same he has two plans in mind to go digital:

- Become a seller on e-commerce websites – he has tried the same but received little traction as customers would enquire about return policies on his products which is currently not there
- Have products available on an online marketplace with agents in each city, who will visit the customers house to show them samples once the customer selects the product from the marketplace. Based on selection and finalization, an online order is placed with him and the agent facilitates the delivery and installation – he needs information on how to explore this opportunity further while mitigating risks for himself (agent is needed because customers need to feel the material before they buy the same.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

Some of the few risks faced by his business are:

- The stock takes 15 days to reach his shop, in case the customer is in a hurry there is nothing he can do about it but stock items which is in itself a risky proposition

Access and usage levels of banking products

He has a savings bank account for a long time, and he prefers taking loan from the bank because of the low interest rates it offers.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

He currently owns a smartphone which he uses for both social media, e-commerce for business and digital payments. While he has been quite comfortable with using the phone, he feels there are a lot of things he needs to learn regarding digital technology which is the most important element for all future businessmen.
While he has a merchant account for PayTM, he still prefers to use Google Pay because of the speed with which the transfer happens.
Digital transactions consist of 15% of the total transaction by customers.

Past learning experience and training support required

While overall, he is very open to learning new things which might help his business, some of the immediate areas in which he feels the need for training through video formats is:

- Digital marketing and its intricacies – on social media and e-commerce websites
- Digital record-keeping

Session 58

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Semi-urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Nupur Kumar Rao
Gender	Male
Age	42
Education	B Com.
No. of members in the family	Adult: 2 Children:1
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Photo studio
Bank account ownership	Bank account in BoI
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 50,000-60,000
Category of respondent	2

Business establishment

His family had a food manufacturing business to create aachaar, jam, jelly and sauces. And he noticed that the same required huge fixed and ongoing costs to run the business, including the intensive nature of tasks. Therefore, in 2011 he decided to set-up a photo studio after going through a few training courses and due to his interest in the area. When he set-up his shop there was a great demand for photography, but for the past 3-4 years young competitors started using the social media channel to market themselves, which has impacted his business adversely. To mitigate the risks, he has tried to diversify into photocopy, printing and even tracing camera's, since he has a lot of knowledge on the subject.

Managing business activities

He has not registered his business, due to ongoing issues with the corporation of his area. As a result, he is not able to avail loan. Once he is able to get loan he plans to set-up an editing studio in his home, which will help him save on costs as he currently outsources the editing work. He is also willing to learn how to avail loan through mobile applications.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

The major risk that he faces is that business is running into extinction. He feels there is a need to diversify before it is too late. But he has no clear vision about it.

Access and usage levels of banking products

He has a positive perception about the bank, but a not so positive perception about other types of institutions like PayTM or Airtel who he feels are foreign bodies who have come to India to only loot the public. His trust in the banking system dwindles further after Aadhaar came into the picture since he feels it is not ready to address issues related to data protection.

He also does not trust digital payments and feels cash is the best form of exchange and the safest. He feels even if one has to use digital payment modes, with cheque and bank money transfer solutions (NEFT/IMPS/RTGS) are adequate to serve the needs of the larger population. And government needs to focus on digital literacy rather than bombard the public with millions of solutions.

While I have taken an LIC product to secure my daughter's future, I do believe banks should also offer such a product.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

He currently owns a smartphone and uses various social media modes to share his political views on certain issues. A few years ago, he tried using JustDial and paid a sum of INR 12,000 for a yearly subscription. He mentioned that this subscription did not benefit him in getting new customers and after this bad experience he has become weary of digital channels for business. He feels all of them are a hoax.

Past learning experience and training support required

He feels apart from the training content, a few success videos of customer feedback from people who have benefitted from the training can be shown.

On the other hand, some of the few areas he might feel the need for training is:

- Availability of new and upcoming cameras in the market
- Ways to increase chances to get a loan from the bank without a security deposit –had not heard about the MUDRA loan
- Ways to avail loan through mobile applications

SanDisk
Panasonic
DVD-R
REDMI NOTE 5 PRO
MI DUAL CAMERA

ALO CHAYA
Digital. Studio
Photo
REDMI NOTE 5 PRO
MI DUAL CAMERA

Session 59

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Jadavpur
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Semi-urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Gaurav Saha
Gender	Male
Age	29
Education	Graduation
No. of members in the family	Unmarried
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Trade
Bank account ownership	Yes
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 20,000-50,000
Category of respondent	1

Business establishment

He runs an ancestral roadside shop alongside his father. The shop does a brisk cigarette business along with other FMCG goods. The expansion and diversification from cigarette to other goods was dictated by needs from customers who came enquiring to the counter.

Managing business activities

The father and son duo are smart in running their business as they deliberately open their shop during the lean time of the day in the afternoon when commuters find only their shop open on the road. Father sits during these lean hours giving son the rest to come to the shop in the evening, read for the anticipated rush.

He is extremely smart at reading the mind of the customers, like the good marketer. As evidence, as we speak, a child arrives asking for a chocolate and he tells us that the reason the child has come is on the item per se but the accompanying toy. He is spot on as the child after going comes within a couple of minutes back demanding the toy!

Again, he is careful in terms of items he stocks in his shop. He doesn't stock Thumbs Up even though volume-wise its sales are more; give the constraint he has in terms of space, he would rather stock Pepsi which gives him a better margin even with limited sales. But he is oblivious of the fact that most of the customers will not be able to see what all he stocks as all that is hidden in the dark shelves at the back wall of his shop.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

He has resigned to the fact that for most of the customers, his shop will purely be associated with cigarette and other tobacco products. He complains that the shop on the other side of the road is able to attract customers for the same products that he stocks as well simply because that shop is air-conditioned and looks like selling branded FMCG products. He doesn't do anything to attract such customers to his shop instead. When probed, he mentions that even if we return to the shop a year from now, we would notice nothing much has changed in terms of his conduct of business. Only if customers increase somehow at his shop, he might organically feel like making some structural changes or reinventing business model in his shop. For example, if let's say four

customers come into his shop in a month asking for ice-cream that he doesn't stock currently, he will interpret a trend and may order a cold storage refrigerator for his shop.

Access and usage levels of banking products

He wants to take a loan from the bank to expand his shop. Since he can't expand his shop sideways on the roadside, he would rather like to increase the depth of his shop providing more space to stock. He has only recently come to know that banks can finance such a small loan for him. [He is speaking of MUDRA loan.] On probing, he mentions that he hasn't been aware of this financial product all this while since the scheme is a few years old. All his family members have their own separate bank accounts, but the shop doesn't have any current account. But they hardly do any bank related transactions for their business as they have deal with suppliers' day-in day-out.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

As is typical of young people, he is fully digital and spends a lot of time online, the father complains. He has done a few digital courses as well but is currently unemployed. This has frustrated him as he has ended up joining his father's general trade.

They do not use Paytm for payments at the shop as they have had frustrating experience when money gets stuck there, proving difficult to put it to any use.

Past learning experience and training support required

He hasn't received any past training for managing his shop better. He would be interested in such a training if delivered through the videos on his mobile phone. He would watch these videos if they interest him. But he has great reservations about the success of such a training program: he feels that there are no such specific skills that he needs to know to manage his business better. As he says, '*cigarette aur Pepsi bechne mein kya training chahiye*'. He says that training like ours would be more useful in villages where people don't know how to even withdraw money from an ATM.

Day 5 (14th June, 2019)

Session 60

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Jadavpur
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Semi-urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Soumen Das
Gender	Male
Age	44
Education	Graduation
No. of members in the family	Adults: 2 Children: 1
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Services
Bank account ownership	Yes
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone
Monthly revenue from business	INR >100,000
Category of respondent	3

Business establishment

Soumen runs his printing and photocopying shop in a residential areas of Jadavpur, with a regular and loyal clientele due to over 15 years of establishment. He has registered trade license to run his shop. The shop is actually a front of his house.

Managing business activities

He epitomizes a lesson in successful diversification and responding to market dynamics. He had earlier started out with an STD shop in the old days of '90s. With changing times, he moved into selling mobile phones and recharges. Sensing a steady decline in that business, he has increased the portfolio of activities to 3-in-1 photocopying machine, lamination, spiral binding, etc. Moving further, seeing that his shop is ideally located in a residential neighborhood, he has started stocking cold storage counters of chocolate and ice cream. The counters have been installed by the brands themselves.

Earlier in one part of his shop, he used to run a cyber café. Now with the lack of popularity of that concept, he has given the vacant space to his wife in which she has recently started a garments retail business. Soumen has also started taxi rental bookings as a service offering, given that many people in the neighborhood and their connections need transportation services. He does concede however that in cab rental services he faces tough competition from many existing providers, but he is here for the long run as well. He feels it takes time to establish oneself in any new line of business, as people don't associate you with that branch for an initial time being. Finally, he has given some of the rooms in his house on rent to students since this area is in the vicinity of prestigious Jadavpur University. He provides them student mess services too. He has also taken the dealership of water tankers and supplies them to 8–10 clients as of now.

He is off late contemplating entering into major regular grocery items like milk, eggs, coffee, etc. Many people in the neighborhood have gone past his shop enquiring about the same. If he is able to successfully add groceries to his stable and his wife is able to grow and expand her garments business, it would provide enough hedges against any market risk.

[*The above is in stark contrast to another such services proprietor we met on Day 2, who didn't foresee the decline in mobile recharge and sale business, and is even today under the impression that he understands his local area very well.]*

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

He doesn't want to keep workers for managing so many of these businesses that he now has. He believes that either they provide sub-optimal customer services or try siphoning off money. This actually prevents him from opening the shop for long continuous period given the diversity of business he now operates. (His wife can support him up to a limit, as she is exclusively focused on growing her garments business liasoning with artisan-weavers in rural Bengal.)

Access and usage levels of banking products

He hasn't taken any loan up till now to reach this current stage of successful diversification. He believes in slow, incremental progress (*showing a status quo arising out of availability – his business has grown slowly over the years – he knows it and wants that to continue*). He deals entirely in the cash with money moving from one business to other.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

He feels amused by the fact that many sales guys keep coming to him every now and then selling their apps. He hasn't been doing any digital bookkeeping, relying solely on the records in the register. He will be open to learn about any product that can help him in digitizing the records.

Past learning experience and training support required

He hasn't attended any training to successfully grow his business. He would like to receive business lessons on negotiations, sales pitch (so as to sell a different brand of a product he stocks as against the demand of the customer for another brand), product diversification, etc. These are essential skills as he goes about establishing himself firmly in all the branches he operates in. More importantly, he feels that there can be motivational videos provided as well to stick around in the business; currently, he takes care of this 'job' watching inspirational videos on YouTube from diverse walks of life.

He would prefer such videos on his WhatsApp, he doesn't mind being made part of a WhatsApp group as well. With videos he has the advantage that he can pause and attend to the customer. And, also watch it again and again.

Session 61

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Rural
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Group
Name of respondent	Gita Das, Roma Roy, Supriya Monda, Chaya Sub
Gender	Female (all)

Age	48,45,31,39
Education	5th class, 10th class, 10th class, 10th class
No. of members in the family	Adult: 2 Children:2
Business is primary income source	No, Yes, No, No
Business type	Stitching clothes, General store, Office canteen, Tiffin service
Bank account ownership	Yes
Type of mobile phone	Basic phone, feature phone, Smartphone, feature phone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 20,000-50,000
Category of respondent	1

Business establishment

Most of the women in this group had to start or be part of their respective business around 4-10 years ago to support their family income. Most of their husbands have a full-time job with not enough income to support the family completely. While some of these women converted their hobbies of stitching and cooking (tiffin services) into a business, others started managing their dying family business i.e. office canteen and general store. While the women who converted their hobbies into business operate from their home and have had a slow trajectory of income growth, the other group operates from the shop which is located closer to their home and have been able to show a very high trajectory of growth and are now managing these businesses independently.

Managing business activities

All the women mentioned that they chose this particular business since it required very low investment as well as because of the rolling nature of income. While all of these women are single handedly running the respective businesses, they have adequate support from their families to help them with domestic responsibilities. They believe it is the income they are able to bring into the household because of which they have this family support and feel if the income goes down or the business runs into losses, the support might not be there. On financial matters related to the business, their husbands or other male members in the family help them. They mentioned that even while deciding to put money in their business, they need to consult the same with their husbands/family first. Also, investment in business is related to either buying raw material or stock. They do not believe there is any other way to expand business or increase business income.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

Some of the major risks perceived by these women is:

- Competition in the area as a result of low skills required for anyone to run a business similar to theirs
- Sudden change in market dynamics or rules and regulations which might hamper their business income e.g. GST

Access and usage levels of banking products

All women have bank accounts but the primary usage is limited to taking loan from Sarla microfinance. They are aware of other products like savings but it is their husbands who primarily manage this aspect of their personal and business life. As a result they have no other interaction with financial services.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

Most of the women current own either a basic or feature phone with their usage limited to calling only. They sometimes wish they would be able to use other features of the phone, but mentioned the lack of time as the primary reason because of which they did not feel the need to buy a smartphone.

Past learning experience and training support required

The women mentioned that although they would want to learn independently from their families, they would need a lot of hand-holding to be comfortable on-boarded for training.
Some of the areas in which the women felt they needed some support is:

- Financial management (personal and business) – such that they can independently manage finances without being dependent on their husbands or other male members in the family
- Usage of mobile phone or applications

Session 62

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Rural
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Papiya Mondal
Gender	Female
Age	33
Education	12th class
No. of members in the family	Adult: 2 Children:1
Business is primary income source	No
Business type	Garment trading
Bank account ownership	Yes
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 20,000-30,000
Category of respondent	1

Business establishment

After her son started going to school, she had some free time in which she started a part-time business as a Oriflame agent. After facing repeated issues of payment installments from customers, she decided to start garment trading based on suggestions from her friends. She gained the requisite experience regarding the business from her friends after which she first bought some stock from the market and then started selling in her neighborhood. After which, she associated with a few boutiques of her friends and started selling their clothes through WhatsApp. She would create a WhatsApp group of all her customers and start sharing pictures of the boutique collection and would earn a commission on every product sold. She mentioned that the margin on the boutique collection was more than the readymade garments she sold but the challenge was when two of her customers liked the same boutique piece. She would have to face difficulty in handling these customers. As a result, she started focusing more on the readymade garment business.

Managing business activities

Papiya mentioned that her husband was working at the commission office and was earning well, so her business was only a means to pass her time and not contribute to the family income and as a result she paid little attention to it. She mentioned that operating the business from her home is very convenient as it helps her to manage her household duties easily as well. Her husband also helps her in her business when she is not at home. Currently, because of her son's studies she has not been able to give adequate time to her business and might think about expanding the same when her son finally goes off to college.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

Some of the risks perceived by Papiya are:

- Financial risk – when she receives a lot of orders from customers, and she does not have enough cash to pay the suppliers (as most people prefer to make payment only after receiving the product).

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

Papiya has a smartphone which she has been using regularly for her business. She mostly uses WhatsApp and Facebook, which she learnt to operate with help from her friends. While she is aware regarding various digital payment techniques, she has never felt the need to use them as she feels cash is the most secure form of payment mode for her small business.

Past learning experience and training support required

Papiya has preference for a digital medium of training as she cannot leave her house to attend training programmes. Some of the few topics on which she believes she might need training are:

- Using social media to market and sell products
- Information of possible boutiques in her adjoining area

Session 63

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Semi-urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Joy Ghosh
Gender	Male
Age	48
Education	10th class
No. of members in the family	Adult: 2 Children:2
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Hosiery manufacturing
Bank account ownership	Bank account in Allahabad bank and CBI
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 90,000-100,000
Category of respondent	2

Business establishment

His grandfather started this business more than 35 years ago and he has been managing it on his own for the past 18 years. He has been getting bulk orders from a dealer on behalf of the brand Lux. His unit has the responsibility to cut, stitch, fold, press and package the material. While his employees (7-8) at the unit manage most of this activity, he outsources the folding activity to a group of women in his area. When his grandfather established the business, he bought the machines from Lux on installments, and he is still using the same machines, even though newer versions are available in the market. He mentioned that one item takes around 30 mins each to complete and package for delivery.

Managing business activities

While he has no direct contract with the Lux brand, it is only through the dealers that he gets orders. He is required to travel to the dealer location to offload and deliver products. He has realized that he needs to expand his business slowly so he has taken up another space on rent near his house for business as he believes taking up more business volumes is the only way for him to expand his business. While he understands his business well,

he feels his dealers have more bargaining power over him even though he has been associated in this business for a long time, probably because there are 20 more similar units like him alone in this area. Also, even if he wants he cannot start taking orders from other brands as the dealers will get to know of the same and this practice is strongly discouraged.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

Some of the major risks perceived by him for his business are:

- Dependent on dealers for order volumes
- Fire in his unit – Lux financed a fire insurance product for his unit after a fire in a nearby unit resulted in loss of raw material for the company
- Wear and tear of his machines – since his machines are old and rudimentary they require a lot of maintenance which is slowly increasing on a yearly basis
- Employees on leave – he has had to cancel orders because a bulk of his employees went on leave suddenly. He has not started thinking of having permanent employees as the frequency of his orders is not certain at times.

Access and usage levels of banking products

He used to have an old bank account in United Bank of India and he has also recently opened a bank account in Allahabad. The purpose of opening a second bank account was that his payment (via cheque) which he received from Lux would take almost 4 days to process. So he decided to open an account in the bank where Lux also has an account and from where his cheque are processed. He mentioned that recently the order volume and frequency has increased which pushed him to make this decision.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

He has a smartphone which he is adequately comfortable with and mostly uses WhatsApp to interact with his friends. Otherwise, he has very limited use of his phone and he mentioned that as a gap area which he tries to cover by taking help from his children.

Past learning experience and training support required

He feels he would prefer the training content on below topics in the form of videos of 15-30 minutes each:

- Latest machines available in the market for his business
- How to increase his bargaining power while dealing with brands
- Ways to make employees to take less leaves

Session 64

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Jadavpur
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Rural
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Group
Name of respondent	Sreeparna Chakravorty, Mallika Mondal, Joni Das
Gender	Female
Age	33, 36, 36
Education	12th, 10th, 10th
No. of members in the family	Adults: 2 Children: 1
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Trade, Manufacturing

Bank account ownership	Yes
Type of mobile phone	Feature phone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 20,000-50,000
Category of respondent	1

Business establishment

They have decided to join these businesses because either they are ancestral trade or they have manufacturing skills in tailoring. While one of the group participant has an old stationery shop running for a long time, other trade outlets on ready-made garments has the shop adjacent to her home itself such that she can take care of the house simultaneously. The group participant who has a tailoring unit has relocated the shop from an ancestral place to a new location where she feels there can be more customers. The participants working in garment trade and tailoring are more adept at their profession and can independently run the shop, the participant involved in stationery trade just manages the shop for the time being while her husband is away. All of their shops are not registered and they do not know the benefit of obtaining one.

Managing business activities

They run their shops with daily customer footfall. They do not maintain any records for their transactions. Generally, they have their fixed suppliers and customers.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

The biggest challenge for these participants is that they are unable to think of the adequate skills that can help in running or growing their businesses. In many cases, they are not able to handle the downturn. They require skills in how to manage these risks and manage the transition when they relocate to another shop.

Access and usage levels of banking products

There major access to banking services is either through a joint account (with husband) or a personal savings account. They hardly save money in their accounts as not much is left to save anyway. Their major access to financial services broadly is through their Sarla microfinance loan, which they have continued for almost a decade now. They have graduated from a small loan to one worth INR 50K now. They have taken the current loan either for the expansion (in terms of putting more stocks in the shop) or for relocating, as in the case of the tailoring shop.

Past learning experience and training support required

They haven't had any past experience in training. They would be willing to have such a training in physical or online mode through a tablet. They feel that if they are provided training on negotiations with customers and suppliers, they can get better margins for their businesses. Also, they would be willing to learn the means of bookkeeping as they feel that if they start doing themselves without the training they might make mistakes. Also, they do not have full awareness of where to source supplies from, especially in the case of participants involved in the trade sector. They either accompany their family members to the suppliers or give the whole charge to their menfolk to complete the

purchase. If they are told about the possible avenues they can explore to source their supplies from—and combined with training on negotiation skills—they can independently run their enterprises much better.

Session 65

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Jadavpur
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Rural
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Sunetra Ghosh
Gender	Female
Age	36
Education	Graduation
No. of members in the family	Adults: 3 Children: 1
Business is primary income source	No
Business type	Services
Bank account ownership	Yes
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 50,000-100,000
Category of respondent	2

Business establishment

She is an enterprising women who runs a website development business. The business is 4 years old and is gradually maturing. Both she and her husband runs the business, aside from their day jobs. The business is registered and complies with all statutory requirements.

Managing business activities

Both she and her husband manage the work taking out time from their routine jobs. They want to take the website development full-time over a period of time, as the future is all online. They have 5–6 workers, generally fresher, who work part-time after their studies as a side income. They generally work from her house. She has arranged for laptops on which they can work. She sources new clients on different portals online. She considers her employees as her biggest strength and is mindful of their welfare as a priority, giving them cash advance payment or work from home option. She is aware that she must offer something to employees such that they can build a career after their graduation.

As part of the website development, they design Facebook pages, landing websites Twitter page, etc. As part of the business development, they have to set up Skype calls with clients. They have many international clients as well, whom she considers are much better do deal with as compared to native clients. She has a young daughter who is good at French, and comes useful when dealing with French clients. She believes as she grows up and hones her skills in different languages, she will be an asset to the enterprise. Depending upon the quality of website development, they earn good reputation from clients who refer them to others in the network. Slowly they have started graduating from smaller, simple projects to bigger and complex projects.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

One of the biggest she faces access to adequate capital. While banks will not give her a bigger loan, her MFI doesn't suffice for her business needs. A situation may arise that her enterprise has won a contract to execute a project, but she doesn't have capital to buy laptops or hire workers with the existing working capital. She

needs to have projects coming on a rolling manner and in parallel such that she can put capital from one project to another if required. Also, multiple engagements keep the employees motivated.
Another big challenge is dealing with the requirements of particular clients, who may have difficult expectations. She feels she and her employees may not have the skill sets to execute the project, thus depriving them of growth and building their credentials in the marketplace. It is again linked to access to capital, as she can use it to acquire the skills needed in the business.

Access and usage levels of banking products

She had applied for bank loan but didn't get it because of their complex requirements like employee papers, IT returns, etc. The MFI loan is much quicker and hassle-free by comparison. The particular loan she has availed currently will last for two years. She has been the MFI client for last four years. She doesn't use a current account for her business, as there are minimum balance requirements. The MFI loan is much easier to repay as there are small fortnightly installments which doesn't burn a hole in their revenues each month and yet makes them credit-disciplined.

Access and usage levels of digital infrastructure

Given that they are fully in to the online world, they are very familiar with the digital payments and other tools. They use RTGS and NEFT for ensuring payments transfers from their clients. She uses Paytm as well to pay her employees sometimes. Yet she is not aware of all the apps in the world which can make her business more seamless and efficient.

Past learning experience and training support required

She has not attended any past learning training. She will be interested in attending such training through online videos. She believes such videos should have a story-line format such that she and her employees can follow it better; it is much better than someone giving a pure lecture which may all be good in theory but not telling how to put into practice. As she expands her existing business and imagines venturing into other areas of her interest as well (like kindergarten in a part of her house), she would require complex management skills. She would need negotiation skills to deal with suppliers and clients, financial management skills to manage the expenses, human resource management skills to take care of employee engagement and satisfaction, and skills on business development to expand and diversify her client base.

Session 66

Respondent profile

Particulars	Responses
State	West Bengal
District	Kolkata
Location type (Rural, Semi-urban, Urban)	Urban
Session Type (Group/Individual)	Individual
Name of respondent	Manoj Kumar Shaw
Gender	Male
Age	46
Education	10th

No. of members in the family	Adults: 2 Children: 2
Business is primary income source	Yes
Business type	Trade
Bank account ownership	Yes
Type of mobile phone	Smartphone and feature phone
Monthly revenue from business	INR 20,000-50,000
Category of respondent	1

Business establishment

Manoj runs a small Kirana shop in one of the alley behind a prominent multiplex of Kolkata. Earlier he had this shop running on rent, since 2014 he has bought it and is currently paying back the loan (INR 2.5 Lakh). The reason for finally buying the shop is that he had managed to get a footing into the business and one of his ancestral shop run by his brother was nearby, giving him an emotional reason as well to buy some shop. His brother has helped him out all these years in establishing the shop, since the brother owns the original ancestral shop. Initially to get business from suppliers, his brother had to persuade them putting himself as a guarantor.

Managing business activities

He runs the shop through direct relations with suppliers who provide various FMCG products on a daily basis. He has the clientele of both kinds—poor people living in a neighborhood nearby and the middle classes living in the gated community close by. He gets the orders from the latter mostly through telephonic orders and delivers them through his sons who help him out in the business. He doesn't charge any delivery charge nor mandates a minimum delivery amount. He generally makes a sale of INR 7–8K per month, catering to about 150 customers. He ensures that suppliers replace the old and expired products in his shop on a real-time basis.
He runs credit lines with suppliers for up to 15 days, which gives him much needed flexibility as compared to taking a bank loan with rigid structures.

Risks or challenges faced and perceived in business. Ways to handle them.

His biggest concern is to ensure he has regular footfall of customers. He is aware that there is a lot of movement in terms of trade happening to the online world. Yet he is unable to either align with this boom or protect himself from the onslaught. He thinks that to work with online majors like Big Basket and Grofers, he would need access to capital to expand his product offerings. Also, as of now he is unaware of how to go about doing business with them online, as he doesn't have the digital skills. He would want to learn how to buy things for his shop online, especially those products which have fragmented supply chain like vegetables, eggs, etc. (He is not aware of UDAAN app that we saw another kirana shop owner use during our research.)

Access and usage levels of banking products

He has a basic savings account, which he uses very sporadically. He doesn't know about a current account. He has limited scope for banking as he generally runs credit relations with suppliers and customers.

Past learning experience and training support required

He hasn’t attended any training in the past relating to development of business skills. He will prefer the training to be in a physical format even if that involves him taking time out of his shop business. He is a migrant from Bihar, so would prefer training to be conducted in Hindi. He is so busy at his shop, doesn’t have time to watch videos. After the initial physical training, the rest of the training can be continued digitally on phone as well. On phone he will be interested in game-based learning modules since the only thing he currently knows how to do on smartphone is playing games. (For calling purposes, he uses his feature phone.)

He would specifically like to own a machine which can print the bills for customers. He feels giving the bill to the customer would repose more trust in his shop and earn him a better reputation. But he doesn’t know where to go to buy the machine and how to use it.

He is broadly interested in any training support that can help him expand his business, maintain and grow relationships with suppliers and take care of his personal finance.